My Toddler Has Chores and It's Not What You Think

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When I tell people my three-year-old has chores, they picture something out of a Victorian novel. She does not scrub floors. She has exactly two jobs, and both of them take about ninety seconds.

Job one: socks in the basket. Every evening, after bath, the socks come off and go in the laundry basket by the bathroom door. That's it. The basket is three feet from where she stands. Some nights a sock lands on the floor next to it and she picks it up with the gravity of a surgeon retrieving a dropped instrument.

Job two: wiping the table. After dinner I hand her a damp cloth — just water, no spray — and she wipes her placemat. It takes four passes. The table is somehow wetter after she finishes than before she started. I wipe it again when she's not looking.

I started this because I read somewhere that toddlers who contribute to the household develop responsibility, and I rolled my eyes at myself even as I tried it. But here's the thing nobody told me: it's not about the help. The help is useless. She once "helped" me fold laundry by sitting inside the laundry basket wearing a pillowcase.

It's about the look on her face.

When she drops the socks in the basket, she turns to me and says "I DID IT" like she just landed a plane. When she finishes the table, she inspects it, nods, and announces "all clean." She is proud in a way that has nothing to do with praise — I barely react anymore, and she still does the little nod. She has a job, she does the job, she is a person who does jobs. You can see her standing slightly taller on the walk back to the living room.

The flop: I got ambitious. I tried to add a third job — putting her folded shirts in the drawer. Disaster. The drawer was too high, the shirts unfolded immediately, she got frustrated, I got frustrated, and we both ended up sitting on the bedroom floor while she cried because "the shirts

are broken.” Two jobs. The number of jobs is two. I have learned my lesson and I am not adding a third until she is at least applying for mortgages.

What surprised me most is that she reminds ME. If I forget the cloth after dinner, she tugs my sleeve and says “wipe?” like I’m the one slacking. Which, fair.

I’m not raising a tiny employee. The socks would get in the basket faster if I did it myself, and the table would actually get clean. But every evening, for ninety seconds, my daughter is competent and she knows it. That’s worth a damp table.